

Lab 01: Data Wrangling and EDA
Foreign Gift Giving Analysis

Executive Summary

Overall, foreign gifts to U.S. colleges and universities are dominated by a small group of countries and a small group of schools, and UVA is currently a pretty small player in this space. Qatar is the single biggest donor of money, and Carnegie Mellon is the single biggest recipient, and just a handful of elite research schools take in most of the dollars. UVA received about \$22.2 million total, which is only 0.13% of all the money in the dataset, and UVA falls well behind peer schools like UC Berkeley and Michigan. My recommendation is that UVA should try to build relationships with countries that already give a lot to UVA's peer schools but currently give little or nothing to UVA, such as England, China, Japan, Germany, and Switzerland, since these countries have already shown they are willing to donate to similar institutions.

Summary of Initial Analysis

Looking at the dataset as a whole, most gifts come in as either a 'Contract' or a 'Monetary Gift', with only 11 gifts total classified as 'Real Estate'. Contracts are both the most common gift type (about 17,274 gifts) and bring in the most money by far, totaling around \$10.8 billion, while monetary gifts total about \$5.78 billion across roughly 10,936 gifts. Qatar is the country that gives the most money overall (\$2.7 billion), England sends the most individual gifts (3,655 gifts), and Bermuda gives the largest gifts on average (about \$7.7 million per gift). Carnegie Mellon University receives the most money overall (\$1.48 billion), and UCLA receives the most individual gifts (3,916 gifts). The single largest flow of money from one country to one school is Qatar to Cornell University, at just over \$1 billion. When looking at the mean versus median gift amount per university, there are clear differences for a few schools, such as Brigham Young University-Idaho, which occur because the school received only a few very large gifts, which pulls the average up, even though most of its actual gifts were much smaller, resulting in a smaller median.

When looking specifically at UVA, donations were a lot smaller than more well known research schools. UVA received about \$22.2 million total across only 98 gifts, which comes out to an average gift of about \$226,421 and a median of about \$80,536. The countries giving the most to UVA are Bangladesh (\$4.2 million), Sweden (\$4.0 million), and Tanzania (\$2.8 million), which is a very different list from the countries compared to those that dominate the overall dataset (Qatar, England, China, Saudi Arabia, and Bermuda). Compared to three peer schools, UC Berkeley (\$294.5 million, 394 gifts) and Michigan (\$287.3 million, 715 gifts) each brought in over ten times more money than UVA, and UNC-Chapel Hill (\$41.3 million, 286 gifts), our closest peer school, received almost double what UVA did. This shows that UVA is not just behind the very top schools in the dataset, but also behind schools that are usually considered similar to UVA.

Strategy for Finding New Sources of Money

To find new potential sources of foreign giving, I compared how much money each country gives to UVA's peer schools (UC Berkeley, Michigan, and UNC-Chapel Hill combined) versus how much that same country gives to UVA. My goal was to see that, if a country is already giving a lot of money to schools similar to UVA, but is giving little or nothing to UVA itself, that country is a realistic target since it has already shown interest in this type of institution. The top five biggest gaps I found were with England (peers received \$78.3 million vs. UVA's \$2.0 million), China (peers received \$63.9 million vs. UVA's \$0), Japan (peers received \$49.5 million vs. UVA's \$266 thousand), Germany (peers received \$41.0 million vs. UVA's \$0), and Switzerland (peers received \$42.1 million vs. UVA's \$2.0 million).

Based on this, I believe UVA should prioritize outreach to England, China, Japan, Germany, and Switzerland, since these are the countries with the biggest gap between what they give to similar schools and what they currently give to UVA. China and Germany stand out the most because UVA currently receives no contributions from them despite peer schools receiving tens of millions, meaning UVA may not have an existing relationship yet. UVA's advancement office should focus on building connections with alumni, corporate partners, or foundations based in these countries, and could also look at what kinds of gifts (research contracts vs. monetary gifts) these countries tend to give to Berkeley, Michigan, and UNC, so UVA can offer similar kinds of partnerships.

Conclusion

Overall, UVA currently receives a small share of foreign gift money compared to its peer institutions and to the top-receiving schools in the country, only making up about 0.13% of the total market. That said, this also means there is a lot of room for UVA to grow, especially since the data shows several countries that are already giving significant amounts of money to schools similar to UVA but are not yet giving much (or anything) to UVA itself. If UVA can build stronger relationships with countries like England, China, Japan, Germany, and Switzerland, there is a realistic path for UVA to substantially increase its foreign gift income over time.